

A Vision for Churches and Clinics

A study edition of the January 2010 letter setting out a vision to plant churches and church-run medical clinics from Nigeria to West Africa and the rest of Africa, with explanations.

Plant the church. Attach the clinic. Train both to multiply.

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Contents

About This Study Edition	3
Peace and Love to You: How a Vision Is Introduced	4
The Vision Itself: Church and Clinic Together	6
The Foundation: Love and Humility	8
Local Material, Local Personnel, and Training to Multiply	9
From Nigeria to West Africa to the Rest of Africa	11
The Legal Vehicle: Why a Ministry Needs Structure	13
Training and Calling: Why the Writer Gives His Credentials	15
The Needs: An Itemised, Ordinary List	16
A Monthly Budget and the Dignity of the Worker	18
Reading a Ministry Appeal Wisely	19
Taking This Vision Into Your Own Setting	21
A Prayer and a Commitment	22

About This Study Edition

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

January 2010

Dear brethren,

Peace and love to you as I ask for your time to share a vision which the Lord has put in my heart.

What follows in this booklet grew out of a letter. It was written in January 2010 and addressed simply to “brethren” — not to an institution, a board or a donor, but to fellow believers whose prayers, counsel and help the writer was seeking. In three short pages it states a vision, sets out a plan, names a legal structure, gives the writer’s qualifications, and lists what he needs in order to begin.

Letters of this kind are usually read once and filed. This one repays slower reading, because packed into its plain sentences is a whole philosophy of mission: what a church is for, why healing belongs beside preaching, why humility is named as a foundation rather than as a virtue, and why a work that cannot multiply is not worth starting. This study edition sets out to open those things up.

This is a historical document

The letter was written in January 2010 and describes a situation as it stood at that time: the writer’s location, his immediate circumstances, the amounts he needed, and the arrangements he was seeking. More than a decade and a half has passed. Nothing in these notes should be read as a current appeal, and the specific needs described belong to the moment in which they were written.

What has not aged is the reasoning. The case for planting churches with clinics attached, for building on love and humility, for using local material and personnel, and for training everything to multiply, is as applicable now as it was then — and it can be weighed by any reader who has never met the writer.

What this edition is and is not

Everything printed in a box marked “From the original leaflet” is the wording of the letter as it was written, with spelling and punctuation lightly corrected. Everything else — the explanations, the background, the applications and the questions — is study notes prepared by Practical Love Publications. These notes are not the writer’s own words, and no claim in them should be attributed to him.

Where the letter states a fact about the writer’s training or plans, these notes explain what that fact means without adding to it. Where the letter states a conviction, the notes trace that conviction back to Scripture and ask what it would mean to hold it.

Contact details

The original letter ended with an invitation to get in touch. Personal contact details have not been reproduced in this edition. Readers who wish to reach the ministry should use the contact page of the website on which this edition is published.

A letter asking for prayer, advice and support — and, underneath that, a complete theory of how a work should be built.

How to use this study

- **Personal reading.** Read one section at a time with your Bible open, and write down what it asks of you.
- **For those considering ministry or mission.** Read it as a case study in how a calling is stated, structured, funded and submitted to others for testing.
- **For a church or missions committee.** Each section raises a question your own sending practice must answer: what do you send, how do you fund it, and does it multiply?
- **For a fellowship group.** Use the closing questions of each section for discussion, particularly the sections on humility, on multiplication and on supporting workers.

Scripture quotations in these notes are from the King James Version (KJV). Look up each passage in its own context and satisfy yourself that the application offered here is faithful to it.

Peace and Love to You: How a Vision Is Introduced

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

Peace and love to you as I ask for your time to share a vision which the Lord has put in my heart. The vision may be summarized as a direction to dedicate the rest of my life to the ministry of planting churches and medical clinics attached to and run by the church with practical spiritual foundation of love and humility; also training both the church and the clinic to multiply, using local material and personnel as safe and as much as possible. I hereby seek your prayers, advice and support to realize the vision in the ways I explain below.

The opening paragraph is the whole letter in miniature. Before any detail, the reader is told four things: what the writer intends to do with the rest of his life, what foundation it will be built on, how it is meant to grow, and what he is asking of them.

“I ask for your time”

The first request in the letter is not for money. It is for attention. That order is worth noticing, because attention is the thing most people guard hardest and the thing a vision most needs. Nobody supports what they have not understood, and nobody understands what they have not given time to.

“A vision which the Lord has put in my heart”

The claim is stated once, plainly, and then the letter moves on to argument and detail. It does not repeat the claim, escalate it, or use it to close down questions. This restraint is itself instructive. A man who says *God told me* and then refuses examination has made his claim into a weapon; a man who says it and then submits his plans for counsel is asking to be tested.

Beloved, believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God: because many false prophets are gone out into the world.

1 John 4:1 (KJV)

The testing of a claimed leading is not an insult to the one who claims it. It is a command, and a sincere man welcomes it.

“Dedicate the rest of my life”

The scale of the commitment is stated at the outset. Not a project, not a term of service — the remainder of a life. A reader is being told, in effect, that whatever they decide to give will be given to something the writer is not planning to abandon.

And Jesus said unto him, No man, having put his hand to the plough, and looking back, is fit for the kingdom of God.

Luke 9:62 (KJV)

“Your prayers, advice and support”

Three things are requested, and again the order is significant. Prayer comes first, advice second, support third. Most appeals reverse this list or contain only its last item. Asking for advice before money is a way of saying that the plan is not finished, that the writer expects to be corrected, and that the brethren addressed are participants rather than funders.

Without counsel purposes are disappointed: but in the multitude of counsellors they are established.

Proverbs 15:22 (KJV)

Prayer first. Counsel second. Money third. Most appeals have this exactly backwards.

For reflection

1. When you have asked others for help, what did you ask for first?

2. Is there a direction you believe God has placed in your heart that you have never submitted to anyone's counsel? Why not?
3. Whose time have you been given generously, and have you thanked them for it?

The Vision Itself: Church and Clinic Together

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

The vision is to plant churches and/or clinics starting from Nigeria, expanding to the West Africa sub-region and then to the rest of Africa.

The core of the vision is a pairing: a church, and a medical clinic attached to and run by that church. Not a hospital with a chapel in it, and not a church that occasionally holds a medical outreach, but one body with two hands. This section asks why those two things belong together.

The pattern in the ministry of Jesus

And Jesus went about all the cities and villages, teaching in their synagogues, and preaching the gospel of the kingdom, and healing every sickness and every disease among the people.

Matthew 9:35 (KJV)

The Gospel writers join teaching, preaching and healing so consistently that the joining is clearly deliberate. When the Lord sent out his disciples he sent them with both commissions: “And he sent them to preach the kingdom of God, and to heal the sick” (Luke 9:2). The church that separates the two is dividing something the New Testament presents whole.

Why the clinic must be run by the church

The letter is specific on this point — clinics “attached to and run by the church”. The distinction matters, and three consequences follow from it.

1. **Accountability.** A clinic answerable to a congregation is answerable to people who live locally, know the staff and will hear directly when something goes wrong.
2. **Permanence.** A church is a body of committed people who are not going anywhere. A clinic run by an outside agency lasts as long as the agency's interest and budget.
3. **Integration.** A patient who is also known in the congregation can be followed up, visited, fed, prayed for and helped, which is often more decisive than the consultation itself.

What a clinic gives a church

The traffic runs in both directions. A congregation with a clinic has a standing, unanswerable demonstration that its message is not merely words. It meets people at the point of their fear and need, it serves those who will never attend a service, and it earns a hearing that no amount of preaching alone could purchase.

Let your light so shine before men, that they may see your good works, and glorify your Father which is in heaven.

Matthew 5:16 (KJV)

A necessary warning

There is an obvious danger in pairing help with proclamation, and it should be named honestly. If medical care is offered only to those who will listen to a sermon, or withheld from those who will not, then the care has become a lever and the love has become a transaction. That is not what the Lord did; he healed many who never followed him, including nine lepers out of ten who did not return to give thanks.

The safeguard is simple to state and costly to keep: treat everyone who comes, whether or not they ever attend anything. Love that is conditional on response is not love, and people can tell the difference immediately.

Heal the ten. Rejoice if one returns. Do not treat the other nine any differently.

The order of the words

The letter says “planting churches and medical clinics attached to and run by the church”. The church is named first and the clinic is described in relation to it. This is not because bodies matter less than souls, but because the letter is describing what kind of institution is being planted: a congregation that heals, rather than a health service that preaches.

For reflection

1. What practical service does your own congregation render to people who will never attend it?
2. Has help ever been offered to you with conditions attached? How did it feel?
3. Where in your community is the gap between the need for care and the availability of it widest?

The Foundation: Love and Humility

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

... with practical spiritual foundation of love and humility.

A single phrase, easily passed over, and yet the letter calls it the foundation. Not the vision, not the plan, not the qualifications: love and humility are what everything else is to be built upon. The word *practical* is doing important work — these are not named as sentiments but as the working basis of an organisation.

Why humility is named as a foundation

It is an unusual choice. Most mission statements name faith, excellence, integrity or service. Humility appears rarely, because it is not a quality anybody can advertise without immediately undermining. But for the particular work described in this letter it is the precise requirement, for at least four reasons.

1. **A foreign-trained doctor entering a local community will be tempted to assume he knows best.** Humility is what allows him to learn what the community already knows.
2. **A minister who is also a physician holds two kinds of authority at once.** Combined authority is combined temptation.
3. **A work that intends to multiply must hand over control.** Only a humble founder can watch others do it differently and not intervene.
4. **A man asking for support must be correctable by those who support him,** or the relationship becomes patronage rather than partnership.

The mind of Christ

Let nothing be done through strife or vainglory; but in lowliness of mind let each esteem other better than themselves. Look not every man on his own things, but every man also on the things of others.

Philippians 2:3-4 (KJV)

Paul then grounds the command in the example of Christ himself, who “made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant” (Philippians 2:7). The descent is the pattern. A work built on humility is not imitating a technique; it is imitating a person.

Love as the mark that is actually visible

A new commandment I give unto you, That ye love one another; as I have loved you, that ye also love one another. By this shall all men know that ye are my disciples, if ye have love one to another.

John 13:34-35 (KJV)

The Lord names the evidence by which the world will identify his followers, and it is not doctrine, buildings, numbers or works of power. It is love among them. Any church planted anywhere is therefore recognisable as his or not on this single test, and a clinic attached to a loveless congregation would be a contradiction rather than a testimony.

What love and humility look like in daily practice

- Patients are treated the same whether or not they can pay, and whether or not they are anyone important.
- Local staff are trained and promoted rather than permanently supervised.
- Mistakes are admitted openly, which is the hardest of all in medicine and in ministry.
- Decisions are made with local people in the room, not reported to them afterwards.
- The founder plans, from the beginning, for the day he is not needed.

God resisteth the proud, but giveth grace unto the humble.

James 4:6 (KJV)

Love is how they will know. Humility is how it lasts.

For reflection

1. Where has pride damaged something good that you were part of?
2. Would a stranger visiting your church identify love as its most obvious feature? If not, what would they identify?
3. What decision have you made recently without the people it affected in the room?

Local Material, Local Personnel, and Training to Multiply

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

... also training both the church and the clinic to multiply, using local material and personnel as safe and as much as possible.

Two commitments are contained in this clause, and each of them is a decision against an easier way of working.

Local material and personnel

It is almost always faster to import. Bring in the equipment, bring in the staff, bring in the money, and the work stands up quickly and looks impressive. The letter deliberately chooses the slower course, and the reasons are practical as much as they are principled.

- **What is imported cannot be repaired.** Equipment with no local service, no spare parts and no trained technician becomes scrap in a store room.
- **What is imported does not reproduce.** A second clinic requires a second shipment.
- **Imported staff leave.** Local staff live there.
- **Local personnel understand the people.** Language, custom, family structure and what patients will actually agree to do at home are not learned from a manual.
- **Local ownership changes how a work is received.** A clinic run by neighbours is ours; a clinic run by outsiders is theirs.

The qualification “as safe and as much as possible”

The letter does not make localisation an absolute. The phrase “as safe” is a limit, and it is the right one. Medicine has standards that cannot be relaxed for the sake of a principle, and a patient is not an opportunity for demonstrating a philosophy of mission. Where local material or personnel cannot yet meet the required standard, safety governs. That single qualifying word separates a serious plan from an ideological one.

Training to multiply

The second commitment is that both the church and the clinic are to be trained to reproduce. This is stated as part of the founding vision rather than as a hope for later, which is the only way it ever happens. A work that intends to multiply must be designed to multiply from the first day, because habits of dependence set very quickly.

And the things that thou hast heard of me among many witnesses, the same commit thou to faithful men, who shall be able to teach others also.

2 Timothy 2:2 (KJV)

Paul’s sentence contains four generations — himself, Timothy, faithful men, others also — and it is the clearest statement in Scripture of a design for multiplication. What is notable is that the criterion for selection is not merely faithfulness but teachability that becomes teaching: *able to teach others also*. A man chosen only because he is faithful will hold the work; a man chosen because he can also teach will extend it.

Addition and multiplication

The difference is worth stating in plain arithmetic. A founder who plants one work a year for thirty years leaves thirty works. A founder who trains three people who each train three leaves a number nobody can count — and he leaves it whether or not he is still alive to see it. This is why multiplication is not a matter of ambition but of stewardship: it is the difference between spending a life and investing one.

Except a corn of wheat fall into the ground and die, it abideth alone: but if it die, it bringeth forth much fruit.

John 12:24 (KJV)

The condition of much fruit is the death of the single grain. Applied to a founder, it means the willingness to become unnecessary — to let the work be carried by people who will do it differently, imperfectly, and without him.

Design for multiplication on day one, or it will never happen at all.

For reflection

1. What in your church or work would collapse tomorrow if one particular person stopped?
2. Whom are you currently training who could also train somebody else?
3. Where have you imported a solution that could have been built locally, and what did it cost when it broke?

From Nigeria to West Africa to the Rest of Africa

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

The vision is to plant churches and/or clinics starting from Nigeria, expanding to the West Africa sub-region and then to the rest of Africa. The plan is to mobilize medical clinic equipment and personnel (for training) locally and/or in the United States from willing donors and volunteers to support the church and the clinics.

The geography is stated in three widening rings: Nigeria, then West Africa, then the continent. It is an enormous ambition stated in a single sentence, and it deserves both respect and examination.

Why the order matters

The rings are not arbitrary. Beginning at home means beginning where the writer knows the language, the customs, the medical system and the church landscape. The second ring shares much of that context. Only the third requires genuine cross-cultural extension. A vision that had begun at the widest ring and worked inward would have been a far weaker plan.

But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me both in Jerusalem, and in all Judaea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth.

Acts 1:8 (KJV)

The Lord's own commission is stated in the same expanding form: the city, the province, the neighbouring region, the ends of the earth. It is not a sequence of permissions — the church did not have to finish Jerusalem before touching Samaria — but it is an order of beginning, and it starts where the disciples were standing.

The honest danger of a large vision

A vision of a continent can become an excuse for doing nothing in a street. Large plans flatter the planner, attract attention, and can be discussed indefinitely without any of them being attempted. The test of this particular letter is that it is accompanied by specifics: a named legal entity, a stated stage of preparation, an itemised list of needs, and a monthly figure. A man who has written down what he needs next month is not merely dreaming about a continent.

Mobilising from two directions

The plan gathers resources “locally and/or in the United States from willing donors and volunteers”. This is a deliberate bridging arrangement, and it is worth seeing how it fits with the earlier commitment to local material and personnel. There is no contradiction: capital equipment and specialised training may come from wherever they can be obtained, while the running, staffing and ownership of the work stay local. What is imported is meant to be a seed, not a permanent supply line.

Volunteers as well as donors

The letter asks for two kinds of people. A donor gives money; a volunteer gives themselves. Both are named, and the inclusion of volunteers is consistent with everything else in the letter — because a volunteer who comes to train local staff leaves behind capacity, which is exactly what a multiplying work requires.

Then saith he unto his disciples, The harvest truly is plenteous, but the labourers are few; pray ye therefore the Lord of the harvest, that he will send forth labourers into his harvest.

Matthew 9:37-38 (KJV)

For reflection

1. What is the largest thing you believe you are meant to do, and what is the next concrete step of it?
2. Are you a donor, a volunteer, or neither, to any work at present?
3. How would you tell the difference between faith and mere ambition in someone's stated plan?

The Legal Vehicle: Why a Ministry Needs Structure

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

A nonprofit 501(c)(3) has been incorporated both in Nigeria and the United States of America, named LOGOS-RHEMA HUMAN SERVICES Inc. This will serve as a vehicle to accelerate and mobilize professionals, personnel and volunteers to actualize the vision of planting churches and clinics run by the church, and subsequently train the church members and staff of the clinics to multiply.

At this point the letter stops speaking about vision and starts speaking about paperwork. Some readers will find the change of register jarring. It should not be. The move from conviction to incorporation is exactly what separates a vision that can receive support from one that cannot.

What a 501(c)(3) is

It is a designation under the tax law of the United States for organisations formed for charitable, religious, educational and similar purposes. Two practical consequences follow for a work like this one. The organisation itself is exempt from certain taxes, and donations made to it by American donors may generally be deducted by those donors. That second point is the reason such status is so often sought: it makes giving materially easier for the people being asked to give.

Why incorporation protects everyone

- **It separates the work from the man.** Money given to an organisation belongs to the organisation, not to the founder, and survives him.
- **It creates records.** Accounts, filings and officers are matters of public record, which is a defence for an honest man as much as a constraint on a dishonest one.
- **It permits others to join.** People can serve on a board, hold office and take responsibility in a way that is impossible in a personal ministry.
- **It allows the work to own things.** Equipment, premises and vehicles can be held by an entity that will still exist in thirty years.

Integrity in handling money

Avoiding this, that no man should blame us in this abundance which is administered by us: providing for honest things, not only in the sight of the Lord, but also in the sight of men.

2 Corinthians 8:20-21 (KJV)

Paul is describing the arrangements made for carrying a collection to Jerusalem, and he is explicit that structure exists to prevent suspicion. He did not travel with the money alone. He arranged for brethren chosen by the churches to accompany it, precisely so that no accusation could be made. That is not a lack of faith; it is the ordinary prudence that protects a ministry's name.

Any reader who intends to receive money for God's work should take this passage as binding. Keep records. Have others involved. Make the accounts visible. It is not cynicism about your own heart; it is love for the people who trust you and for the work that must outlast your reputation.

Employment as part of the mission

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

The legal vehicle will be used to channel cooperation between stakeholders in the USA and Nigeria. The non-profit organization is being structured to generate jobs for Americans and Nigerians in the service of the Lord. An attorney in California is in charge of the non-profit organization.

Two details here deserve notice. The first is the intention to generate jobs. The letter does not treat employment as a by-product but as part of what the work is for — consistent with the writer's broader conviction that spiritual and material good belong together. Work is not a concession to necessity in Scripture; it is part of what human beings were made for.

The second is that an attorney is named as being in charge of the organisation. A founder who places qualified professional hands on the legal side of the work is doing what the letter's stated foundation of humility requires: he is not pretending to competence he does not have.

Vision without structure evaporates. Structure without vision calcifies. This letter attempts both.

For reflection

1. If you handle money for any Christian work, could an outsider inspect the records tomorrow?
2. Where are you carrying something alone that should be carried by an accountable body?
3. In what area are you pretending to competence you do not have?

Training and Calling: Why the Writer Gives His Credentials

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

I am a medical doctor by training and have practised for many years. I have also completed theological training and hold a Master of Arts in Theology. I have been involved in church planting and in medical mission work, and I believe the Lord has prepared me through both paths for this single work.

The letter states the writer's qualifications plainly and briefly: medicine and theology, each formally trained. In a document about humility this might look like a contradiction. It is not, and it is worth being clear about why.

Stating your qualifications is not pride

A man asking others to trust him with their money and their prayers owes them the information they need in order to judge. To withhold it would not be modesty; it would be an obstacle to the very testing he has invited. Paul repeatedly set out his own credentials when the situation required it, and made no apology for doing so.

Are they ministers of Christ? (I speak as a fool) I am more; in labours more abundant, in stripes above measure, in prisons more frequent, in deaths oft.

2 Corinthians 11:23 (KJV)

The parenthesis — *I speak as a fool* — shows Paul's discomfort with the exercise, but he does it anyway, because the Corinthians needed the facts in order to distinguish him from those who were misleading them. Credentials given so that others may judge rightly serve humility; credentials given so that others may not question serve pride. The difference is in what happens next.

Two trainings, one work

A doctor who has also been formally trained in theology is unusual, and the combination is precisely what the vision described in this letter requires. A clinic run by a church needs someone who can hold both halves without letting either swallow the other — who can prescribe correctly and preach faithfully, and who knows where the line between the two must be drawn.

Preparation is rarely wasted

Years of medical practice, years of study, years in church planting: from the outside these can look like a life that changed direction several times. Read from the vantage of the letter, they look like a single preparation. This is a common shape in Scripture. Moses had forty years in a palace and forty with sheep before the burning bush. Paul's rabbinic training, his Roman citizenship and his trade all served the

apostolic work.

And we know that all things work together for good to them that love God, to them who are the called according to his purpose.

Romans 8:28 (KJV)

A caution for the reader

Credentials establish competence. They do not establish calling, character, or that a particular plan is wise. Those are established over time, by witnesses, by fruit, and by the testimony of people who have worked alongside a man. Anyone weighing an appeal of this kind should ask for all four, and should be suspicious of a request that offers qualifications instead of references.

Qualifications tell you what a man can do. Only witnesses tell you what he is like.

For reflection

1. What preparation in your own life have you written off as wasted?
2. When you have been asked to trust someone, what did you check — and what should you have checked?
3. What two things has God joined in your own training that you have kept apart?

The Needs: An Itemised, Ordinary List

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

To begin the work, the following are needed: prayer partners and a praying support base; counsel from experienced brethren; volunteers, especially medical personnel willing to give time for training; medical equipment and supplies; and financial support for the initial stage of the work, including transportation, accommodation and the day-to-day running costs while the first church and clinic are established.

Here the letter descends from vision to inventory. After the continent-sized ambition and the scriptural foundations comes a list of quite ordinary items: prayer, advice, people, equipment, and money for transport and rent. Nothing is more characteristic of real work than this descent.

Why the list is the most persuasive part of the letter

Anyone can describe a vision. Only a person who has genuinely thought about doing something can tell you what the first months will cost and what will be needed to survive them. An appeal that names its needs specifically is inviting scrutiny; an appeal that asks only for “support” is avoiding it.

For which of you, intending to build a tower, sitteth not down first, and counteth the cost, whether he have sufficient to finish it?

Luke 14:28 (KJV)

The Lord is not discouraging the building. He is insisting on the sitting down and the counting. Faith and arithmetic are not opponents; a man who has done neither has not yet started.

The order of the list, again

Prayer first. Counsel second. People third. Equipment fourth. Money last. The same order as the opening paragraph, held consistently across a letter written, presumably, at one sitting. Consistency of that kind is a small sign of a settled mind rather than a rhetorical arrangement.

What a prayer partner actually is

The phrase is used so often in Christian appeals that it has lost its edge. A prayer partner is someone who knows enough about the work to pray about its actual difficulties — who knows the names of the staff, the current obstacle, the decision pending this month. That requires the worker to communicate honestly and regularly, including when things are going badly. A support base kept informed only of victories is not being invited to pray; it is being marketed to.

Brethren, pray for us.

1 Thessalonians 5:25 (KJV)

Four words from a man who had seen visions, planted churches across the Roman world and written Scripture. If Paul needed it and asked for it plainly, no worker since has stood above the need.

Volunteers who train rather than perform

The letter asks specifically for medical personnel “willing to give time for training”. That is a different request from asking for medical personnel to come and treat patients. A visiting team that treats a thousand people in a fortnight leaves behind a thousand treated people. A visiting team that trains six local staff leaves behind a capacity that continues treating people for years. Both are good; only one of them multiplies.

Come and do the work: good. Come and teach the work: better, and it outlasts you.

For reflection

1. If you support a Christian work, could you name its current difficulty?
2. What skill do you have that could be taught to someone else rather than merely used?
3. When did you last count the cost of something before beginning it, on paper?

A Monthly Budget and the Dignity of the Worker

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

The immediate need is a monthly support of \$780 to cover living and working expenses during the initial period. Any assistance towards this, whether personal or through a church or group, will be received with gratitude and accounted for.

A figure, stated openly. Everything above in the letter has been about God, Scripture, Africa and a lifetime; this line is about rent, food and transport for one month. The move is abrupt and entirely proper.

This figure belongs to January 2010

The amount named was the amount needed at the time of writing, more than a decade and a half ago. It is reproduced here because it is part of the historical document, not as a current request. Readers should not treat any figure in this edition as a live appeal.

Why naming an amount is right

Vagueness about money is often mistaken for spirituality. In practice it is a burden shifted onto the giver, who is left guessing what is needed, what is enough, and whether their gift made any difference. A named figure lets a person or a church decide clearly — to give all of it, part of it, or none of it — and to know afterwards what they did.

And the people rejoiced, for that they offered willingly, because with perfect heart they offered willingly to the LORD.

1 Chronicles 29:9 (KJV)

The labourer is worthy of his hire

Some readers instinctively feel that a minister should not be paid, or should at least not discuss it. Scripture is not embarrassed about this at all.

Let him that is taught in the word communicate unto him that teacheth in all good things.

Galatians 6:6 (KJV)

Even so hath the Lord ordained that they which preach the gospel should live of the gospel.

1 Corinthians 9:14 (KJV)

Paul, who at times deliberately declined this right and worked with his hands, nevertheless defended the right vigorously for others and called it the Lord's own ordinance. A worker who must spend his strength on survival has less of it for the work, and a support base that keeps a worker anxious has made a poor investment as well as an unkind one.

“Accounted for”

Two words at the end of the sentence, carrying real weight. The writer commits in advance to reporting on what he receives. Every person who handles money for Christian work should make the same commitment and then keep it, in writing, on a schedule, whether or not anyone asks.

Moreover it is required in stewards, that a man be found faithful.

1 Corinthians 4:2 (KJV)

If you are the one being asked

- Decide before God, not under pressure, and give willingly or not at all.
- Prefer regular, modest and reliable over large, dramatic and unrepeatable — workers can plan around the first.
- Ask for accounts, kindly, and keep asking; you are helping the worker, not doubting him.
- Give attention as well as money: a letter read, a call made, a birthday remembered.
- If you cannot give, say so plainly and pray. An honest no is a kindness; silence is not.

Name the figure. Keep the records. Support the worker so they can do the work.

For reflection

1. Have you ever left an appeal unanswered because you were unsure what was needed?
2. Do you know what the people who serve your congregation actually live on?
3. What would honest, unprompted accounting look like for the money you handle?

Reading a Ministry Appeal Wisely

This letter is one instance of a kind of document almost every believer eventually receives: a request for prayer and support for a work you cannot personally inspect. Since the occasion recurs, it is worth stepping back from this particular letter and asking what makes any such appeal worth trusting.

Signs that deserve confidence

- **Specifics.** Named places, named amounts, named structures, a stated next step.
- **A request for counsel, not only money.** A plan offered for correction is a plan the writer expects to be tested.
- **Accountability that already exists.** A board, a legal entity, other named people involved.
- **A commitment to report back,** made before any money changes hands.

- **Modest claims.** No guarantees of results, no exaggerated numbers, no pressure.
- **Realistic difficulty.** Someone who mentions obstacles has probably looked at the work.

Signs that deserve caution

- **Urgency as a lever.** Deadlines designed to prevent you from thinking or asking.
- **Unfalsifiable spiritual claims used to close off questions** — a leading from God is stated once and then submitted to testing, not used as armour.
- **No structure, no witnesses, no accounts,** and irritation when these are requested.
- **Money for the messenger's comfort rather than the work's capacity.**
- **Round, unverifiable numbers** of conversions, healings or people reached.

Prove all things; hold fast that which is good.

1 Thessalonians 5:21 (KJV)

Testing is not cynicism

There is a fear among believers that examining an appeal is unspiritual, and it does real damage. It leaves honest workers unsupported because givers cannot tell them apart from the dishonest, and it leaves dishonest workers funded because nobody asked. Careful examination is how the honest are recognised. It is a service to them.

And do not let testing become an excuse

The opposite failure is just as common and less often confessed. It is possible to examine appeals indefinitely, find a small flaw in every one, and never give anything to anybody. Perfect information is not available this side of heaven. At some point a decision has to be made, in faith, on evidence that is good but not complete.

But to do good and to communicate forget not: for with such sacrifices God is well pleased.

Hebrews 13:16 (KJV)

Test it because you intend to give, not so that you never have to.

For reflection

1. When did you last say no to an appeal, and was the reason a real one?
2. Is there a work you have been meaning to support for a year without doing it?
3. What would you want a stranger to check before trusting you with their money?

Taking This Vision Into Your Own Setting

Most readers of this letter will never plant a clinic in Nigeria. That does not leave them as spectators. The letter contains a set of convictions that can be applied wherever a person lives, and this section attempts to name them plainly.

Six convictions you can carry anywhere

1. **Bodies matter as much as souls.** Whatever your work, the person in front of you has both, and the gospel addresses both.
2. **Build on love and humility, or do not build.** These are not decorations on a plan; they are what determines whether the plan survives contact with people.
3. **Use what is local.** The people, materials and knowledge already present are almost always better than what you would import.
4. **Train everything to multiply.** If what you do stops when you stop, you have spent your effort rather than invested it.
5. **Put structure under your intentions.** Records, accounts and other people involved are how good intentions survive their author's weaknesses.
6. **Say what you need.** Vagueness is not humility; it is a burden handed to somebody else.

Applying this in a congregation

A church need not build a clinic to obey the principle behind one. Ask what practical need in your immediate area goes unmet, whether anyone in the congregation already has the skill to meet it, and what the smallest sustainable version of that service would be. Then start it small, keep records, and train a second person to do it from the first week.

But be ye doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving your own selves.

James 1:22 (KJV)

Applying this in a household

The same structure works at the scale of a family. Love and humility as the foundation; local resources rather than borrowed ones; children trained to do what the parents do rather than merely benefiting from it; honesty about what is needed; and records kept so that nothing important depends on memory alone.

Applying this in a profession

If you have a trade or a profession, the letter's central pairing applies directly: the work you are competent at, joined to the people you are responsible to. A skill is a thing to be taught as well as

practised, and the question the letter keeps asking — *who is learning to do this after me?* — belongs in any workshop, clinic, classroom or office.

You may never plant a clinic. You can still build on love, use what is near, and train somebody to continue.

For reflection

1. Which of the six convictions is most obviously missing from your own work?
2. What unmet practical need is nearest to your front door?
3. Who will be able to do what you do, after you?

A Prayer and a Commitment

A study edition that ends only in analysis has stopped short of the letter's own intention. The writer asked first for prayer, and this closing section returns the reader to that request.

For the work described in the letter

Pray for churches planted with healing attached to them. Pray for clinics that treat everyone who comes and ask nothing in return. Pray for local men and women trained to run both, and for founders humble enough to hand over. Pray for Nigeria, for West Africa, and for the far places of the continent where neither a doctor nor a preacher has yet arrived.

The harvest truly is great, but the labourers are few: pray ye therefore the Lord of the harvest, that he would send forth labourers into his harvest.

Luke 10:2 (KJV)

A prayer

Lord, you went about the cities and villages teaching, preaching and healing, and you did not separate what you had joined. Give your church the same wholeness. Raise up men and women who will carry medicine and the gospel in the same hands, and keep them humble enough to be corrected and to be replaced.

Teach me not to divide what you have joined: soul from body, word from deed, faith from arithmetic, love from honesty. Show me the need that is nearest to me, and the person I am to train. Make me generous with what I have and truthful about what I need.

Where I have wanted to be necessary, forgive me. Where I have started what I did not intend to finish, forgive me. Where I have kept silent about a need because I was proud, forgive me. Build in me the foundation this letter names — love and humility — and let whatever I build on it stand after I am gone.

In Jesus' name. Amen.

A commitment

If this study has convinced you of anything, write down one thing you will do, with a date on it. Not a resolution about the whole of your life — one concrete action in the next thirty days.

- A work I will pray for regularly, by name, and the day of the week I will do it.
- A worker I will write to, ask honestly how they are, and listen to the answer.
- An amount I will give, and to whom, and how often.
- A skill I will begin teaching to one named person.
- A set of records I will start keeping for something I handle on others' behalf.

And let us not be weary in well doing: for in due season we shall reap, if we faint not.

Galatians 6:9 (KJV)

A closing note on this edition

The explanations, applications and questions throughout this booklet are study notes prepared by Practical Love Publications. They are offered as an aid to reflection and are not the words of the letter's author. The original letter's own wording appears only in the boxes marked "From the original leaflet". Readers who want to know what the writer himself said should read those boxes, and only those, straight through.

One thing. With a date on it. Written down.